

Non-Technical Interview Preparation

Technical Lead | 17+ Years Experience | TCS

Candidate Profile	
Total Experience	17+ Years
Current Organization	Tata Consultancy Services (TCS)
Current Role	Technical Lead — NPg Project
Additional Roles	Project Manager (small project) + Automation Team Member
Core Tech Skills	Python, Generative AI (GenAI)
Interview Focus	Behavioural, Leadership, PM, Stakeholder & Situational

This document focuses on **non-technical interview questions** that interviewers are most likely to ask a senior Technical Lead with project management and automation responsibilities. Each question includes a structured sample answer and a practical tip on how to deliver it confidently. Use the **STAR** method (Situation, Task, Action, Result) wherever stories are required.

1. Self-Introduction & Career Journey

Q1. Walk me through your 17 years of experience.

Sample Answer:

I have over 17 years of IT experience with TCS, progressing from a developer to a Technical Lead. My journey began in application development, after which I moved into automation engineering, and over the last several years I have been leading delivery as a Technical Lead. Currently I lead the NPg engagement as Team Lead, simultaneously playing Project Manager for a smaller parallel initiative, and contributing as a core member of the automation team. My technical depth is in Python and Generative AI, which I use to build automation accelerators and AI-led solutions for the account.

- *Tip: Keep it under 90 seconds. Structure it as: Past (where you started) → Present (what you do now) → Future (what excites you). Avoid reading the resume line by line.*

Q2. Why have you stayed with TCS for so long?

Sample Answer:

TCS has consistently given me opportunities to reinvent myself — from development to automation, and now into GenAI-led delivery. The variety of clients, domains, and the freedom to drive innovation inside large accounts has kept the work meaningful. I also value the culture of mentorship; I have been mentored well and I now mentor others, which adds to my long-term commitment.

- *Tip: Frame loyalty as a choice, not inertia. Mention growth, learning, and impact — never say 'comfort zone'.*

Q3. What are your key strengths as a Technical Lead?

Sample Answer:

Three strengths stand out. First, technical depth — I can still get hands-on with Python and GenAI when the team needs unblocking. Second, delivery ownership — I run my projects with PM discipline even when not formally titled PM. Third, people leadership — I focus on building T-shaped engineers and creating an environment where the team takes decisions, not just executes them.

- *Tip: Always back each strength with a one-line proof point. Strengths without evidence sound rehearsed.*

2. Leadership & Team Management

Q4. How do you manage a team while also being hands-on technically?

Sample Answer:

I time-box my day. Mornings are usually for team stand-ups, unblocking, and stakeholder calls. Afternoons are protected for design reviews, code reviews, and my own hands-on work on critical or risky modules. I delegate aggressively on routine items but stay involved on architecture, GenAI prompt design, and any automation framework decisions. The principle I follow is — lead from the front on hard problems, step back on solved ones.

- *Tip: Interviewers want to know you don't become a bottleneck. Emphasise delegation + selective deep dives.*

Q5. Tell me about a time you had a conflict within your team. How did you handle it?

Sample Answer:

On the NPg project, two senior engineers disagreed on whether to use a fine-tuned model or a RAG-based approach for a client requirement. The discussion was becoming personal rather than technical. I called a short working session, asked each of them to present trade-offs against fixed criteria — cost, latency, accuracy, maintainability — and let the data drive the decision. We went with RAG. More importantly, I followed up individually with both engineers afterwards to make sure the working relationship was intact. The team now uses that same trade-off template for design decisions.

● *Tip: Use STAR. Show that you de-personalise conflict by anchoring on objective criteria. End with what changed permanently because of how you handled it.*

Q6. How do you handle an underperforming team member?

Sample Answer:

I start with a private one-on-one to understand the root cause — it is rarely just skill. It might be unclear expectations, personal issues, or wrong role fit. I then set clear, written goals for the next two to four weeks with weekly check-ins, and pair them with a buddy where relevant. If performance improves, great. If not, I escalate transparently with HR and the delivery manager, but only after the person has had a fair chance and clear feedback. I never let someone be surprised by an escalation.

● *Tip: Never sound punitive. The interviewer is checking for empathy + structure + escalation discipline.*

Q7. How do you motivate a team during high-pressure delivery?

Sample Answer:

Three things work for me. First, shielding — I absorb noise from stakeholders so the team can focus. Second, visibility — I make sure leadership sees individual contributions, not just my name on the deck. Third, small wins — I break the crunch into 2 or 3 day milestones and celebrate each one, even informally. People burn out from ambiguity faster than from workload.

● *Tip: Mention 'shielding the team' — it's a senior-leader signal. Avoid clichés like 'pizza and late nights'.*

3. Project Management & Delivery

Q8. You play Technical Lead and Project Manager for a smaller project. How do you balance both?

Sample Answer:

I treat them as two distinct hats with different rhythms. As PM on the smaller project, my focus is scope, schedule, risk log, status reporting, and stakeholder communication — typically 25-30 percent of my week. As Technical Lead on NPg, the focus is design, code quality, and team enablement. I keep separate trackers, separate stand-ups, and I block calendar slots so neither role steals time from the other. The PM role has actually made me a better Tech Lead — I plan and communicate more rigorously now.

● *Tip: Highlight that wearing two hats has made you better, not stretched thin. Quantify the time split.*

Q9. How do you handle scope creep from the client?

Sample Answer:

I never say no outright — I say 'yes, and here is the impact'. I take the new requirement, map it to effort, schedule, and risk, and present the trade-off to the client with options: absorb it by deprioritising X, or take it as a change request with revised timeline. This keeps the relationship collaborative and protects the team from silent over-commitment. Every accepted change goes through a formal CR log, however small.

- *Tip: Show you protect the team without being rigid. 'Yes, and here is the impact' is a great phrase to use.*

Q10. How do you handle missed deadlines?

Sample Answer:

First, I never let a deadline miss come as a surprise — early warning is the most important PM habit. The moment I see a slippage risk, I flag it with options: re-scope, add bandwidth, or extend. If a miss does happen, I focus on three things: communicate transparently with the client and leadership, do a blame-free retrospective with the team to find the root cause, and document the fix so we don't repeat it. The worst response is to hide a slippage and hope to recover silently — it always gets worse.

- *Tip: Lead with prevention, then handle the miss with transparency. 'Blame-free retrospective' is a strong phrase.*

Q11. How do you identify and manage project risks?

Sample Answer:

I maintain a living risk register from day one — not a one-time document. Risks are classified by probability and impact, with a clear owner and mitigation plan for each. I review the register weekly in the internal stand-up and share the top 3-5 risks in client status reports so there are no surprises. For the GenAI work specifically, I track risks like model drift, hallucination, data privacy, and dependency on third-party APIs — these need different mitigation than traditional dev risks.

- *Tip: Mention GenAI-specific risks (hallucination, drift, data privacy) — it shows modern risk thinking.*

4. Stakeholder & Client Management

Q12. How do you handle a difficult or demanding client?

Sample Answer:

I assume the demand is legitimate until proven otherwise — clients are demanding usually because something matters to them that we haven't surfaced. I increase the frequency of touchpoints, get their priorities in writing, and align my team's roadmap visibly to those priorities. If the demands are genuinely unreasonable, I escalate within my account leadership rather than absorbing silently or pushing back directly. The goal is to convert a difficult client into a trusting one — not to win an argument.

- *Tip: Never speak negatively about a client, even hypothetically. Show empathy first, structure second.*

Q13. Describe how you communicate status to senior stakeholders.

Sample Answer:

I follow a simple rule — executives want outcomes, not activity. My weekly status note has three sections: what shipped, what is at risk with mitigation, and what I need from leadership. No long narratives, no jargon. Verbal updates follow the same structure. For NPg I also include a one-slide delivery health dashboard — green/amber/red across scope, schedule, quality, and team — which has become the standard format the client expects.

- *Tip: Senior interviewers love structured communication. Mention RAG dashboards, one-pagers, or concise reporting.*

5. Automation & Innovation Mindset

Q14. As part of the automation team, what kind of automation have you driven?

Sample Answer:

My focus has been on automating the boring and the risky. On the boring side — build pipelines, regression test execution, log analysis, and reporting — these freed up roughly 20-30 percent of engineering bandwidth on my projects. On the risky side, I have built Python-based accelerators for data validation and GenAI-assisted code review, which reduce human error in repetitive review tasks. The principle I follow is — automate what is repeatable, document what is not.

● *Tip: Quantify impact wherever possible (% time saved, defects reduced, cycle time improved).*

Q15. How do you decide what to automate and what to leave manual?

Sample Answer:

I use a simple ROI lens — frequency of the task multiplied by effort per execution, against the cost of building and maintaining the automation. Tasks that are frequent, repeatable, and rule-based are clear automation candidates. Tasks that need judgment, are one-off, or change frequently are usually better left manual or semi-automated. I also factor in maintenance cost — automation that nobody owns becomes technical debt.

● *Tip: Mention maintenance cost — it shows mature thinking. Most candidates only talk about building, not owning.*

Q16. How are you bringing GenAI into your delivery work?

Sample Answer:

Pragmatically, not as a buzzword. On NPg, we have introduced GenAI in three places — automated first-draft documentation, code review assistance for junior engineers, and RAG-based knowledge retrieval over our internal project documentation. Each use case had a clear before/after metric before we rolled it out. I am also driving an internal upskilling track so the team understands prompt engineering, RAG architecture, and the risks of using GenAI on client data.

● *Tip: Show that you use GenAI with discipline — metrics, governance, upskilling. Avoid hype language.*

6. Situational & Behavioural

Q17. Tell me about a project failure and what you learned.

Sample Answer:

A few years ago I led a small automation rollout that we shipped on time but adoption was poor — users went back to the manual process within a month. The technical solution was correct; the change management was not. I had under-invested in user training and stakeholder buy-in. The lesson stayed with me — a successful delivery is not 'code shipped', it is 'value adopted'. Since then, every project I lead has a defined adoption metric, not just a delivery metric.

● *Tip: Never claim you have never failed. Pick a real failure, own it cleanly, and end with the permanent lesson.*

Q18. How do you keep yourself technically relevant after 17 years?

Sample Answer:

I treat learning as a non-negotiable, not a hobby. I block 3-4 hours every week for hands-on learning — currently focused on GenAI frameworks, agentic patterns, and Python ecosystem updates. I also build small side-projects to actually use what I learn, because reading alone doesn't stick. Internally at TCS, I take part in CoE discussions and contribute to the automation guild, which forces me to stay current.

● *Tip: Mention specific recent learning. Vague 'I read blogs' answers fall flat for a 17-year senior.*

Q19. Where do you see yourself in the next 3-5 years?

Sample Answer:

I see myself growing into a Delivery Manager or Solution Architect role, owning larger engagements end-to-end. I want to combine the technical depth I have built in Python and GenAI with the delivery rigour I have learned as a PM. Longer term, I would like to lead a practice or a CoE around GenAI-led automation — that intersection is where I have the most to contribute.

● *Tip: Make sure your aspiration aligns with the role you're interviewing for. Show ambition without sounding restless.*

Q20. Why are you open to this opportunity?

Sample Answer:

I am not running from TCS — I am running towards the next challenge. The role you are offering gives me a chance to take on broader ownership, work on problems at a different scale, and apply my GenAI and automation experience in a fresh context. I want my next role to stretch me, and from what I have seen of this position, it does exactly that.

● *Tip: Always frame the move as pull (towards the new role), never push (away from current employer).*

7. Final Interview Tips

- **Use STAR for every behavioural question** — Situation, Task, Action, Result. Keep each story under 2 minutes.
- **Quantify wherever possible** — 'reduced regression time by 40%', 'led team of 8', 'saved 200 hours/quarter'. Numbers separate seniors from mid-levels.
- **Never badmouth TCS, clients, or past managers** — interviewers read this as a future risk, not as honesty.
- **Be specific, not generic** — instead of 'I led a team', say 'I led an 8-member team across India and onsite on a GenAI accelerator for a BFSI client'.
- **Show learning from failure** — every senior is expected to have failed. Owning failure cleanly is a positive signal.
- **Mind the two-hat narrative** — when discussing Tech Lead + PM + Automation, present it as integrated leadership, not as juggling.
- **Prepare 3 strong stories in advance** — one on leadership, one on conflict, one on delivery under pressure. Most behavioural questions can be answered using these three.
- **Ask thoughtful questions at the end** — about team structure, success metrics for the role, and the manager's leadership style. Avoid asking about salary or leave in the first round.
- **Pause before answering tough questions** — a 2-3 second pause signals thought, not hesitation. Don't fill silence with filler words.
- **Close strong** — at the end, briefly summarise why you are a strong fit and express genuine interest. Many candidates lose the offer in the last 60 seconds.

Good luck! Preparation is the difference between sounding experienced and being seen as experienced.